

Bharat says HELLO

Indian corporates join hands with the Government and NGOs to train rural youth for opportunities in the cities

By Malini Bhupta

In a business suit and hair pulled back in a neat chignon, Mangal Kotkar looks like any other young professional. But beneath the veneer of sophistication is a shy village girl, whose fight for a life beyond subsistence has taken her from a sleepy village in Maharashtra to the Taj Hotels. Being a girl child in India, Kotkar had to first battle her family to go to school, but her biggest challenge came when she wanted to leave her father's farm for vocational training in a nearby town. After finishing school, young Kotkar chanced upon Pratham's vocational training in association with the Taj Hotels which would train her for a job in the hospitality industry.

It may not have been easy being the only girl doing the course, but Kotkar successfully completed it because of her strong desire to change her family's fortunes. She is today working for the chain's super premium property Vivanta in Goa and believes she can break the cycle of poverty she has seen all her life. She says: "I will strive to make my parents feel proud and will live up to the name of the Taj by becoming the best housekeeper."

Like Kotkar, 75 per cent of India lives in villages where literacy levels may be as high as 60 per cent, but scarcely ever translating into jobs for the rural youth. Left

out of the country's double digit economic growth for long, the 'other' India is seeing some hope of joining the party, as a handful of companies tie up with vocational training institutes and non-governmental bodies to teach skills to educated but unemployable youth from the hinterland. As such initiatives take off, young boys and girls like Kotkar will be able to join the organised workforce in India by supplementing their school education with market-driven skills.

While the Central and state governments are trying hard to give India's educated population skills and make it employable, there are a large

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